THE HOPE CONNECTION

The Seasons in Scripture

What Each Season Means in God's Calendar

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>
> Genesis 8:22 (ESV)

A Teaching Series from The Hope Connection

“Meeting others where they are in the Name of Jesus”

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Ask a man what fall "means," and he will give you football and leaves. Ask the Bible, and it gives you something sturdier. Scripture does not hang invented symbols on the seasons, the way calendars and greeting cards do. It does something better: it shows us what God actually ordained in each season in the land of Israel — the feasts He commanded, the rains He sent, the work He gave, the harvests He counted — and lets the meaning rise out of the facts. A season in the Bible is not a mood. It is a schedule written by God, and every entry on it preaches. This short series walks the year the way Israel lived it: spring, summer, fall, and winter, in God's own order, asking one question of each — *what did God put here, and what does it say to us?*

Overview — The Year God Made

Scripture: Psalm 74:17; Genesis 8:22; Ecclesiastes 3:1

The seasons are God's idea, and God's property. The psalmist says it in one line: "You have fixed all the boundaries of the earth; you have made summer and winter" (Psalm 74:17). Summer and winter are not accidents of astronomy that God tolerates. He *made* them. And after the flood, standing in a washed world with Noah, God put the rhythm of the year into a covenant promise: "While the earth remains, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease" (Genesis 8:22). The seasons will outlast every empire, every famine, every man's worst year — not because nature is strong, but because God pledged His word to the turning of the year. Solomon compresses the whole thing into a sentence a child can memorize: "For everything there is a season, and a time for every matter under heaven" (Ecclesiastes 3:1). Everything. Including the season you are in right now, whatever it feels like.

Israel's year ran on two tracks at once. God started Israel's religious year in the spring: "This month shall be for you the beginning of months" (Exodus 12:2) — the month of the Exodus, Nisan. But the civil year, the year of kings and contracts and the counting of a man's age, turned in the fall, in Tishrei. So an Israelite lived with two new years: one that began with deliverance, and one that began with atonement. The gospel is hiding in the calendar itself — a man's life with God starts at the Exodus, and his standing before God is settled at the mercy seat.

The spine of the year was rain and grain. Israel's farming turned on two rains God promised to a covenant-keeping people: "he will give the rain for your land in its season, the early rain and the later rain, that you may gather in your grain and your wine and your oil" (Deuteronomy 11:14). The early rain fell in the fall and softened the hard ground for plowing and sowing. The latter rain fell in the spring and fattened the grain before harvest. Between those two rains, God

hung three great harvest feasts — Passover and Firstfruits at the barley harvest in spring, the Feast of Weeks at the wheat harvest in early summer, and the Feast of Ingathering when everything came in during the fall — and around them, Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, Booths, Dedication, and Purim. The feasts were not decorations on the year. They *were* the year.

A farmer's tablet says the same thing. In 1908, workers dug up a small limestone tablet at Gezer, an old Canaanite and Israelite town, dated to about the tenth century before Christ — roughly Solomon's lifetime. Its eight short lines are nothing but farm work, two months at a time: two months of ingathering, two months of sowing, two months of late sowing, one month of hoeing flax, one month of barley harvest, one month of harvest and measuring grain, two months of tending vines, one month of summer fruit. No theology on the stone at all — just the year as a working man lived it. And yet it proves the point of this whole series: in Israel, the calendar, the farm, and the faith were one cloth. A man could not keep the seasons without keeping the feasts, and he could not keep the feasts without being taught, four times a year, who God is.

How to read the four entries. Each season follows the same road: what God ordained in it, what the people actually did in it, the bad news it tells the truth about, and where it lands in Christ. Read them in order — spring's deliverance, summer's labor, fall's ingathering and sowing, winter's hidden seed — and you will find they preach one gospel in four voices. Then, when you have finished, step outside and look at the sky. The season you are standing in is not random weather. It is a page in a book God has been writing since Genesis 8, and He is still turning the pages on time.

Reflection: Which season — deliverance, labor, ingathering, or hidden waiting — honestly describes your life right now? Hold that answer in mind as you read the entry for it.

Spring — The Season of Deliverance

Scripture: Exodus 12; Leviticus 23:5-11; 1 Corinthians 15:20-23; Song of Solomon 2:11-13

The details, as God gave them. Israel's year opened in the spring month of Nisan, and it opened with blood on doorposts. On the tenth day of the month each household took a lamb — "a lamb... without blemish, a male a year old" (Exodus 12:5) — kept it four days, and killed it at twilight on the fourteenth. The blood went on the doorposts and the lintel, the flesh was eaten that night with unleavened bread and bitter herbs, and the destroyer passed over every marked house in Egypt. Then came seven days of unleavened bread (Leviticus 23:6-8). And on the day after the Sabbath of that Passover week, the priest waved the first sheaf of the barley harvest before the Lord — the Feast of Firstfruits (Leviticus 23:10-11). No Israelite could eat a bite of the new crop until that sheaf had been offered: "You shall eat no bread or parched grain or fresh ears

until the selfsame day, that you have brought the offering of your God" (Leviticus 23:14). God got the first handful of every harvest, before any man tasted it.

The bad news spring tells the truth about. Spring, in Scripture, does not begin with flowers. It begins with slavery. The Exodus happened because Israel was in bondage — generations of it, brick quotas and taskmasters, a people who "groaned because of their slavery and cried out for help" (Exodus 2:23). Passover is a beautiful feast, but it is beautiful the way a rescue is beautiful: it only exists because somebody was drowning. And the bitter herbs were on the table on purpose, so that no Israelite would ever celebrate the deliverance while forgetting the bondage it came out of. Spring's first sermon is the one every honest person has to hear: we did not need advice. We needed out.

What the people did, and what the land did. While the lambs were being kept, the latter rain was finishing the grain — the last great rain of the season, swelling the barley and wheat heads before the sickle. Green ears, new lambs, fresh grass after the winter rains: the land itself seemed to start over. That is when the Song of Songs sets its most famous invitation: "for behold, the winter is past; the rain is over and gone. The flowers appear on the earth, the time of singing has come, and the voice of the turtledove is heard in our land. The fig tree ripens its figs, and the vines are in blossom; they give forth fragrance. Arise, my love, my beautiful one, and come away" (Song of Solomon 2:11-13). And it is no accident that Ruth begins in spring. A widowed, empty Naomi walks back into Bethlehem with a Moabite daughter-in-law clinging to her, and the narrator dates the homecoming with a farmer's precision: "And they came to Bethlehem at the beginning of barley harvest" (Ruth 1:22). She came home empty at the exact season God starts things over. Watch what He does with that.

Where spring lands in Christ. Paul takes the two spring feasts and drives them straight to Jesus. Of Passover he writes, "Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed" (1 Corinthians 5:7). Of Firstfruits he writes the sentence that holds the whole Christian hope: "But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20). Christ rose on the first day of the week — the very day the sheaf was waved — and Paul says that is not a coincidence, it is an order: "But each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then at his coming those who belong to Christ" (1 Corinthians 15:23). A sheaf of barley in a priest's hands was God's receipt, guaranteeing the whole field would follow. The empty tomb is the same receipt, written larger. Spring, biblically, is the season of deliverance and new beginnings because in spring God both *did* the delivering — out of Egypt, out of the grave — and *dated* it, so His people would remember every year: this is the season when God brings His people out.

Reflection: What is the "Egypt" God has already brought you out of — and have you thanked Him for the deliverance lately, bitter herbs and all? And if you are still in bondage, hear spring's news: this is the season God specializes in bringing people out.

Summer — The Season of Labor in the Heat

Scripture: Leviticus 23:15-17; Proverbs 10:5; Proverbs 6:6-8; Amos 8:1-2; John 9:4

The details, as God gave them. Fifty days after the waved barley sheaf, Israel counted to the second great harvest feast: "You shall count seven full weeks from the day after the Sabbath… You shall count fifty days to the day after the seventh Sabbath. Then you shall present a grain offering of new grain to the Lord" (Leviticus 23:15-16). This was the Feast of Weeks — Shavuot — falling in late Sivan, at the wheat harvest. Where Passover's bread was unleavened, this feast's offering was the opposite: "You shall bring from your dwelling places two loaves of bread to be waved, made of two tenths of an ephah. They shall be of fine flour, and they shall be baked with leaven, as firstfruits to the Lord" (Leviticus 23:17). The barley belonged to spring; the wheat, the bread-grain of ordinary life, belonged to summer. It was at this very feast, centuries later, that the Holy Spirit fell in Acts 2 and about three thousand souls were gathered in one day — God's wheat harvest arriving on God's wheat feast.

What the land did, and what the people did. After Weeks, the rain simply stopped. From roughly the end of spring until the fall rains, the heavens over Israel were shut — month after month of heat, dust, and a sun that did not negotiate. What rain the ground held had to last. So summer was threshing and winnowing on the hilltop floors where the evening breeze could carry off the chaff. Summer was guarding: the grapes swelling on the vine, the figs ripening — the "summer fruit" that closed the Gezer tablet's year — all of it exposed to thieves, birds, and blight, all of it needing a watchman's eyes. Ruth gleaned straight through this season: she "kept close to the young women of Boaz, gleaning until the end of the barley and wheat harvests" (Ruth 2:23), a foreign widow doing summer work in summer heat, and finding favor she did not earn — which is where grace usually finds people: mid-field, mid-sweat, mid-season.

Summer's wisdom: work now, because the season will not wait. Proverbs builds two of its sharpest lessons out of summer labor. "He who gathers in summer is a prudent son, but he who sleeps in harvest is a son who brings shame" (Proverbs 10:5). And Solomon sends the lazy man to school under an ant: "Go to the ant, O sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise. Without having any chief, officer, or ruler, she prepares her bread in summer and gathers her food in harvest" (Proverbs 6:6-8). Notice the ant's secret: she works in summer for a winter she cannot yet feel. That is the whole of summer's doctrine. The season of labor always arrives before the season of need, and God arranged it that way on purpose. Jesus took the same truth and put eternity behind it: "We must work the works of him who sent me while it is day; night is coming, when no one can work" (John 9:4). Summer is daylight. It is not endless. It is not meant to be slept through.

The bad news summer tells the truth about. Amos saw a basket of summer fruit, and God turned the picture into a funeral. "This is what the Lord God showed me: behold, a basket of

summer fruit. And he said, 'Amos, what do you see?' And I said, 'A basket of summer fruit.' Then the Lord said to me, 'The end has come upon my people Israel; I will never again pass by them'" (Amos 8:1-2). In Hebrew it is a wordplay that lands like a hammer: the word for summer fruit, *qayits*, sounds like the word for the end, *qets*. Summer fruit is fruit at its ripest — and fruit at its ripest is fruit at the edge of rot. A nation can ripen in sin the way a fig ripens in the sun, looking rich and full right up to the day it is gathered for judgment. Summer preaches that harvest is not always good news. Ripeness is a deadline, not a compliment.

Where summer lands, and the month of Elul. By long tradition, the last month of summer, Elul, became Israel's season of preparation — a month of repentance and honest reckoning before the trumpets of Tishrei sounded. Tradition is not Scripture, and this series will not pretend otherwise, but the instinct is a biblical one: the wise man audits his life *before* the audit. It is fitting that Nehemiah's wall — fifty-two days of summer labor under threat — was finished "on the twenty-fifth day of the month Elul" (Nehemiah 6:15), God's work completed at the very end of the working season. So summer stands in Scripture as the season of labor and vigilance in the heat: the grain gathered, the fruit guarded, the days used — because the One who gave the summer also set its length, and the light for working is a gift with an evening attached to it.

Reflection: What has God put in your field for *this* summer — work, gathering, guarding — that you have been sleeping through? And what would it mean to do it now, while it is day?

Fall — The Season of Ingathering and Sowing

Scripture: Exodus 23:16; Leviticus 16; 23:23-43; Psalm 126:5-6; James 5:7; Isaiah 40:6-8

The details, as God gave them. Fall opened the civil year with a trumpet. On the first day of Tishrei came the Feast of Trumpets, "a memorial proclaimed with blast of trumpets, a holy convocation" (Leviticus 23:24). Ten days later, the holiest day of the year: the Day of Atonement, when the high priest alone entered the Holy of Holies with blood, once a year, for his own sins and the sins of the people — "Now on the tenth day of this seventh month is the Day of Atonement. It shall be for you a time of holy convocation, and you shall afflict yourselves" (Leviticus 23:27). Then, on the fifteenth, the year's great celebration: the Feast of Booths, which Exodus calls by its farming name — "the Feast of Ingathering at the end of the year, when you gather in from the field the fruit of your labor" (Exodus 23:16). For seven days Israel lived in booths of branches, on God's orders: "You shall dwell in booths for seven days… that your generations may know that I made the people of Israel dwell in booths when I brought them out of the land of Egypt: I am the Lord your God" (Leviticus 23:42-43). Gratitude with a memory built into it: eat the harvest, sleep in a hut, remember who carried you.

The order of fall preaches. Notice where God put the mercy seat: *before* the ingathering, and *before* the new year turned. Israel did not start the year with resolutions, plans, or a vision board.

It started with blood on the mercy seat and sins confessed and carried away. The new year began with cleansing, and only then came the feasting. That order is a sermon every fall: a man does not get right with God by harvesting harder. He gets right with God the way Israel did — by atonement, provided by God Himself, received by a people willing to afflict their souls and be honest about what the year had actually contained.

Then the feasts end — and the real fall work begins. After Booths came Cheshvan, the one stretch of the year with no feast at all. The barns were full, the celebrations over, and the farmer went back out to a field that was hard as iron after the dry summer. Everything depended on the early rain — the *yoreh* — falling to soften the ground (Joel 2:23). Then plowing. Then sowing: seed carried out into cold mud, buried, and walked away from. Psalm 126 describes a man doing it with tears running down his face: "Those who sow in tears shall reap with shouts of joy! He who goes out weeping, bearing the seed for sowing, shall come home with shouts of joy, bringing his sheaves with him" (Psalm 126:5-6). James takes the same farmer and makes him the picture of patience itself: "See how the farmer waits for the precious fruit of the earth, being patient about it, until it receives the early and the late rains" (James 5:7). Fall is the sowing season — obedience buried in cold ground on nothing but a promise.

The bad news fall tells the truth about. Fall is also when the harvest law becomes visible, and Jesus made it the picture of the end of everything: "The harvest is the end of the age, and the reapers are angels" (Matthew 13:39). What was sown is what gets gathered; the barn and the fire are both real. The prophets preach from the withering fields: "All flesh is grass, and all its beauty is like the flower of the field. The grass withers, the flower fades when the breath of the Lord blows on it; surely the people are grass. The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God will stand forever" (Isaiah 40:6-8). Moses prays the same lesson over falling leaves: "So teach us to number our days that we may get a heart of wisdom" (Psalm 90:12). And the New Testament's one picture of autumn is a warning label: false teachers are "fruitless trees in late autumn, twice dead, uprooted" (Jude 12) — all color, no fruit, leaves with nothing under them. Fall strips every tree down to what is actually alive in it. It does the same to people.

Where fall lands. At the far edge of fall, in Kislev, comes the Feast of Dedication — Hanukkah — remembering the temple cleansed and rededicated under the Maccabees, and John dates a confrontation with Jesus by it: "At that time the Feast of Dedication took place at Jerusalem. It was winter" (John 10:22). So fall, biblically, holds the whole range: thanks for what God gathered in, cleansing before the year turns, seed sown in tears through the quiet months, and a final harvest standing at the end of the age casting its shadow back over every field. The God who counts the harvest is the same God who sends the rain for the next sowing. Fall ends with the seed in the ground and the promise in the heart — which is exactly where winter takes up the story.

Reflection: What has God gathered in for you this year — and have you sat down, booth-style, and thanked Him on purpose? And what seed is He asking you to sow now, in the cold, without seeing the harvest?

Winter — The Season of the Hidden Seed

Scripture: John 12:24; Jeremiah 1:11-12; Esther 9:22; Song of Solomon 2:11

What winter actually was in the land. After the fall sowing, the rains settled in for the season — the long, cold wet months of Tevet, Shevat, and Adar, when the hills ran with water, the wadis filled, and Jerusalem could be genuinely cold. The psalmist pictures a winter sky under God's hand: "He gives snow like wool; he scatters frost like ashes" (Psalm 147:16). There were no feasts of ingathering now, no harvests to carry in. The farmer's work was mostly done, and it was mostly invisible besides: the seed he had sown in the fall lay buried in black, soaked earth, doing nothing that any eye could see. If you judged the year by what a man could point to in the middle of winter, you would call it dead. You would be wrong about the field — and Scripture spends a whole season teaching us not to make that mistake about anything.

The seed must die to live. Jesus took winter's hidden seed and made it the picture of His own cross, and of ours: "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it bears much fruit" (John 12:24). Read the sentence slowly. A grain kept safe in the barn "remains alone" — intact, unrotted, and useless. A grain buried in the cold ground disappears, splits, and becomes a harvest. Winter is the season where God does His deepest work in the dark, underground, at a pace no man can hurry and in a place no man can watch. Dormancy is not death. A vine in January looks like a bundle of dead sticks; the root under it is alive, and the sap will prove it. Scripture's winter is the standing rebuke to everyone who measures God's work by what is visible above the surface — in a field, in a church, in a child, in their own soul.

Winter is the season of waiting, and Scripture is full of it. Abraham waited decades between the promise and the child. Joseph spent years in a prison for a crime he did not commit, in the dark, while the dreams God gave him looked buried past recovery. Israel groaned through long generations in Egypt before the spring of Exodus ever came. And between the last prophet and the angel's announcement to Mary stretches the longest winter of all — centuries of silence, no new word, nothing but the old promises in the ground like seed. What did God say when the silence finally broke? "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son" (Galatians 4:4). The fullness of time. Winter was not God forgetting. Winter was God filling the time to exactly full. If you are in a waiting season — praying the same prayer, burying the same hope, watching a field that shows you nothing — you are not in an empty season. You are in the one where the seed is.

The first sermon of the waking year: the almond tree. At the edge of winter, while every other tree in the land still stood bare, one tree woke first: the almond, breaking into white blossom while the hills were still cold. God built Jeremiah's call around it: "And the word of the Lord came

to me, saying, 'Jeremiah, what do you see?' And I said, 'I see an almond branch.' Then the Lord said to me, 'You have seen well, for I am watching over my word to perform it'" (Jeremiah 1:11-12). Underneath the English is a wordplay every Israelite would have heard instantly: the almond is the *shaqed*, the "watching tree," and God is *shoqed* — watching. The tree that wakes first preaches that God is awake before anything else is: alert over His word while the world still looks asleep, already moving toward performance while the promise still looks buried. The first blossom of the year is God saying, *I have not forgotten a single word I spoke.*

And winter ends the way God loves to end it. The last feast of the cold months is Purim, on the fourteenth of Adar, remembering Esther — a book where God's name is never mentioned once, and His hand is on every page. A winter plot to destroy God's people was turned, in the dark, by courage and coincidence that are not coincidence at all: "as the days on which the Jews got relief from their enemies, and as the month that had been turned for them from sorrow into gladness and from mourning into a holiday" (Esther 9:22). *The month that had been turned.* That is winter's last word in Scripture — not that the cold was imaginary, but that God turns months. And then the year swings back to the Song: "for behold, the winter is past; the rain is over and gone" (Song of Solomon 2:11) — a promise spoken to everyone still standing in the middle of the season it describes as finished. Winter, biblically, is the season of the hidden seed and the watching God: nothing visible, everything in hand, and spring already appointed on the calendar.

Reflection: What has God buried in your life that you have been calling dead? What would it change to call it *seed* instead — and to trust the One who is watching over His word to perform it?

Closing — A God for Every Season

Walk the year once more, the way Israel lived it. Spring: God brings His people out — out of Egypt, out of the grave — and dates the deliverance so no one forgets which season rescue comes in. Summer: God gives work and daylight to do it in, guards the ripening fruit, and warns us that the light has an evening. Fall: God counts the harvest honestly, cleanses His people before the year turns, and sends them back out to sow in tears on the strength of a promise. Winter: God buries the seed, keeps the root alive, watches over His word in the silence, and turns the month of mourning into gladness at the edge of spring.

Four seasons, four sermons, one God — and one more thing worth seeing: Jesus Christ walked in every one of them. He is the Passover Lamb of spring and its Firstfruits sheaf. He is the worker of summer who finished the Father's work while it was day. He is the Lord of the fall harvest, who will gather His wheat into the barn; and He is the grain of wheat of winter, who fell into the earth and died, and did not remain alone. Whatever season you are standing in as you read this — deliverance, labor, ingathering, or the long hidden cold — you are not standing in it alone, and you are not standing in it outside of God's calendar. The same hand that fixed the boundaries of

the earth and made summer and winter has appointed the length of your season too. And He has never once, in all the turning years since Genesis 8, been late turning the page.

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